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Environmental sustainability and customer experience in emerging markets

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Abstract

Increasingly, environmental sustainability becomes an important consideration for customer engagement (CE). The globalization of the marketplace has led to a marketing renaissance focused on environmental sustainability, which highlights the importance of our study. Our research question is, therefore, "How does environmental sustainability enhance customer engagement?" We argue that attention to environmental sustainability in emerging markets would significantly enhance CE. Expanding the customer involvement of green-oriented customers can lead to significant environmental improvement, especially in emerging economies. This study makes significant contributions to research and practice of connecting the environment sustainability to CE in emerging markets. Our study applies a mixed method research design, which involves concurrently using both quantitative and qualitative methods, with quantitative preceding the qualitative and exploratory methods. Our study finds out that CE in emerging markets results in increased environmental sustainability and in this manner, enhances the customer tourism experience.

KEYWORDS
customer engagement, emerging markets, environmental sustainability

1 | INTRODUCTION

Environmental sustainability has increasingly become an essential consideration for customer experience management (CEM). With the fragmentation of the marketing concept and the limited value of customer relationship management CEM is becoming a new exciting field of research (Homburg et al., 2017). This study adds a new dimension, sustainability, to the currently recognized domains of the customer experience literature (Fatma, 2014) and builds on the theoretical foundation for the Sustainable Customer Experience framework suggested by Signori et al. (2019). Recently, some studies have drawn attention to exploring sustainability (green) marketing in the context of tourism to enhance customer experience (Font & McCabe, 2017).

While environmental sustainability has been of recent interest in extant literature (Han, 2021; Panda et al., 2020; Vermeir et al., 2020) because of the increasingly globalized marketing landscape, there has been a limited focus on the customer experience (So et al., 2021), which is an important aspect that interacts with stakeholder orientation and social sustainability (Brulhart et al., 2019; Danso et al., 2020; Soundararajan et al., 2019). Firms cannot ignore this globalizing trend toward customer experience (So et al., 2021). Even when they ignore customer experience in emerging markets, environmental sustainability issues become essential to foreign customer experience dependent on environmental sustainability (Chuah et al., 2020; Piligrimienė et al., 2020). As a result, this study focuses on the impact of environmental sustainability on customer experience. Our research question is: "What parameters can we identify that allow environmental sustainability processes to increase the customer experience?" The

Abbreviations: AVE, average variance extracted; BIO, bio-diversity; CA, Cronbach alpha; CE, customer engagement; CEP, customer experience; CR, composite reliability; HTMT, heterotrait–monotrait; PLS-SEM, partial least square structural equation modeling; VIF, variance inflation factor; WEC, water and energy conservation; WSM, water and sanitation management.

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purpose is to demonstrate that attention to environmental sustainability in emerging markets would significantly enhance the customer experience in those markets because of the current negative environmental impacts being felt, and through this, increased awareness leads to improved environmental conditions.

Environmental sustainability moves beyond green marketing, which has become a buzzword in marketing, and its focus is environmental sustainability (Chopra & Chaudhary, 2021; Singh & Pandey, 2012); green experiential marketing is when environmental sustainability can be added to a brand, which presents unforgettable experiential memories as customers enhance their sense of identity with environmental sustainability (Lee & Peng, 2021; Urdea et al., 2021). The potential for positive effects of environmental sustainability consideration in marketing in emerging markets is exceptionally high (Hassan, 2000). This includes all environmental management practices to conserve and protect the physical environment, such as water conservation and efficient water use, afforestation, efficient management of solid and liquid waste, production of eco-friendly products, and reduced pollution levels.

2 | CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE MANAGEMENT WITH ENVIRONMENTAL SUSTAINABILITY IN EMERGING MARKETS

The overall challenge of environmental sustainability is associated with the need for CEM, especially in some emerging markets where natural resource availability is abundant (Chen et al., 2022; Zahoor et al., 2022). This leads to rethinking central marketing practices and the current conception of customer experience, including the customer touchpoint of environmental sustainability (Chen et al., 2022). This study significantly contributes to the research and practice of connecting environmental sustainability to customer experience supported by environmental exploitation in emerging markets. We integrate CEM practices into business by considering environmental sustainability in emerging markets.

An example of environmental sustainability to enhance customer experience is sustainable marketing, whereby the specific target is a sustainable experience engaging those customers who are affinity for sustainable experiences. However, such opportunities become magnified in emerging markets with CEM. This CEM highlights environmental sustainability in emerging markets with abundant natural resources. We discuss the impact of environmental sustainability on customer experience in the industrial collaboration of emerging markets with considerable natural resources but very little knowledge of green marketing, environmental sustainability, and customer experience. This perspective aligns with Zhang et al.'s (2008) call for a new perspective from cross-national research that further delves into these topics. Our study examines the case of Chinese companies operating in Ghana and found a negative impact on customer experience. Based on what we learned from this experience, we direct environmental sustainability in ecosystems and serve as a resource for green marketing and CEM. Our study provides the various dimensions of environmental sustainability on this customer experience. Customer experience in this context relates to the physical context during tourism and interaction with the ecology in the host nation. In a sense, we are marrying the concepts of environmental sustainability with customer experience, which goes beyond the theories of green marketing by operating at a deeper level.

This paper is structured as follows. The next section describes the theoretical foundation of our conceptual model. Then follows the methodology section, which describes research methods and presents empirical results. This section outlines the research design and methodology to cover the research paradigms, research purpose, research strategy, research approach, data collection, and analysis method. Furthermore, we discuss the research findings, theoretical and managerial implications, and limitations. Finally, we summarize the empirical findings and highlight directions for future research.

3 | CONCEPTUAL DEVELOPMENT

3.1 | Customer experience

Researchers have acknowledged that the recent economy has been changed into an experience economy (Pine & Gilmore, 2011). Several authors indicate that it is no longer satisfactory for firms to offer just commodities, products, or services. Rather, they accompany those services with memorable experiences that differentiate the firms in the competitive arena (Pine & Gilmore, 2013; Schwartz, 2002). Experience dimension(s) is a blend of many consumer dimensions that merge (Shaw & Ivens, 2002) within consumers that involve the emotional, physical, intellectual, and spiritual aspects of experience (Mossberg, 2007) and are memorable (Pine & Gilmore, 1999). Experience dimensions may include potential customer touch points such as information technology (IT), service operations, logistics, marketing, human resources, and even external partners and peer customers in creating and delivering positive customer experiences. Thus, it has become progressively complex for firms to create, manage, and control the consumer experience journey (e.g., Rawson et al., 2013). Customer experience is made more complex with the increasing influence of media, omni-channels, and social media (Leeflang et al., 2013; Verhoef et al., 2015), resulting in more complex customer journeys. The totality of a customer's interaction with other actors on the broader ecosystem, while co-creating the experience has been recognized by many authors (Chandler & Lusch, 2015; Prahalad & Ramaswamy, 2003).

The multidimensional nature of customer experiences involves cognitive, emotional, behavioral, sensorial, and social components (Keiningham et al., 2017) and makes the market experience more experiential. At a cognitive level, experiences can be more abstract, such as a flow experience (Kanagasapapathy, 2017), and this is made even more dynamic with human and media interactions. Therefore, consumer experience is the multidimensional outcome of the consumer's encounters with products, services, and businesses (Walls et al., 2011). In the sustainability industry, this multi-dimensional nature of the consumer experience combining the cognitive, emotional, spiritual, and site-

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communality positively affects human wellness (Brymer & Lacaze, 2013). Hence, the powerful effect of eco-tourism.

Significant attention has been paid to creating experiences for consumers to sustain their patronage of innovations in the context of sustainability. There has been a diverse effort to gain a better understanding of consumer experiences in a variety of consumption environments, including tourism (Schmitt & Zarantonello, 2013). In such contexts, several experiences influence the consumer, such as multisensory, imagery, and emotive aspects (Lemon & Verhoef, 2016) with the intervention from services from hotel employees to enhance the consumer experience (Andersson, 2007). In sustainability industries, the consumer experience can further be enhanced with the intervention of the government to enhance consumer well-being (Fisk et al., 2020). This government intervention can magnify the consumer service experience through the creation of service ecosystems (Akaka & Vargo, 2015). The emergence of service ecosystems with the intervention of government provides greater power and potential to the consumer experience with risk and crisis aversions and resolution (Boscarato et al., 2014). Fisk et al. (2020) indicate that service collaborations provide a wider scope to serve consumers and employees.

Despite the potential of the government to enhance the consumer experience in sustainability industries through collaborations, there have been limited studies in this arena. Emerging markets have exhibited considerable promise to unleash resources in the sustainability context. These resources can be leveraged to enhance the consumer experience in eco-tourism. This study, therefore, explores sustainable collaborations between emerging markets that enhance the consumer experience. Such marketplace wisdom that focuses on government collaboration between emerging markets represents knowledge, skills, competencies, and the power to create relevant operant resources to solve contemporary problems and redefine sustainability (Kadirov & Varey, 2005).

3.2 | Environmental sustainability

Environmental sustainability relates to green marketing, a monumental challenge for firms and marketers (Mckinnon, 2010). The definition of environmental sustainability is relevant to distinguishing between growth and development and positive customer experience from environmental sustainability (Chuah et al., 2020). This leads us to consider configuring the business ecosystem to advance the growth debate (Chuah et al., 2020). The growth debate and sustainability issues are ideally synthesized when environmental sustainability is considered (Rajala et al., 2016). This paper aims to address the conceptual adolescence of environmental sustainability, which ignores CEM as part of the environmental sustainability configuration. It is recognized that involving sustainability in ecotourism experience management leads to greater awareness of sustainability issues (Tsetse et al., 2021). The vast majority of customers from various nations like Brazil, Canada, China, France, Germany, India, the UK, and the US have shown an interest in green marketing to reduce their environmental impact, according to a survey by (Cherian & Jacob, 2012). However, showing interest and acting on the interest are two different actions. Environmental issues are addressed in green marketing efforts to create awareness about environmental issues and how customers can participate in environmental sustainability (Liao et al., 2020). We discuss the theory to date on green marketing and customer experience in the following sub-section of our conceptual development. A combination of these highlights will elucidate the objectives of this study to show how environmental sustainability enhances customer experience in emerging markets and globally.

3.3 | Sustainable marketing and customer experience

Environmental marketing, more extensively known as green marketing or sustainable marketing, can be defined as the effort of a firm to create and circulate products in a way that promotes environmental sustainability (Polonsky, 2011). Today, sustainable marketing is a vital component of marketing research, with increasing media exposure and pressure on firms to present eco-friendly behavior (Chuah et al., 2020). Nevertheless, what about the depletion of the abundant natural resources in emerging markets that could be leveraged for customer well-being and to enhance customer experience? Over time, green marketing growth has been presented as adapting and improving product packaging and sustainable marketing management for an improved global ecosystem (Polonsky & Rosenberger, 2001) and has gone past this initial understanding and extended and become broader. These activities now include environmental protection, which has become the most crucial aspect (Dono et al., 2010). This increased interest in environmental protection led to the "green consumerism" movement (Eriksson et al., 2002). The expansion of green marketing and green customers is "perhaps the biggest opportunity for enterprise and invention the industrial world has ever seen" (Cairncross, 1992, p. 177). A green customer can be identified as one who avoids any product that may lead to the deterioration of the environment during manufacturing or usage, consumes a large amount of non-renewable energy, or harms animals or human subjects (Elkington, 1994). Extensive research over time highlights that expanded awareness of green issues, increased level of information availability on environmental sustenance, green advertising by firms, increased concern for the environment, and an increase in focus on green products by social and environmental charities are examples of this focus. This overwhelming increase in overall environmental sustainability awareness among customers and firms who seek to go green by presenting the concept of corporate environmentalism (Banerjee, 2003) The increasing awareness of sustainability, such as wastewater reduction, has been shown to increase brand loyalty in tourism (Martínez, 2015). Currently, sustainable development is identified by business firms as an opportunity to improve their marketing niche rather than just actions performed by customers and firms. Our study seeks to combine all these perspectives to reorganize the alignment of environment sustainability and customer experience, establish the desired vision for a positive customer experience with

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environmental sustainability, and, in so doing, reconfigure the business ecosystem for CEM with environmental sustainability in emerging markets where natural resources may be abundant and yet have suffered many depredations.

3.4 | Hypotheses

Following the literature above and conceptual development, we propose the following Hypotheses:

H1. Biodiversity positively impacts the customer experience.

H2. Waste and energy conservation positively impact the customer experience.

H3. Waste Management positively impacts the customer experience.

4 | METHODOLOGY

4.1 | Context

Ghana is situated on the Gulf of Guinea and the Atlantic Ocean in West Africa, with abundant natural resources that provide diverse tourist attractions. Along with the fact that Ghana has an impressive economic growth that quadrupled by 2011, there has been a deterioration of natural resources and massive land, air, and water pollution as the country collaborated with foreign countries for the construction of roads, hotels, telecommunication networks, and energy exploration, adversely impacting the customer wellbeing. However, the focus on environmental sustainability could ensure a positive customer experience.

4.2 | China in Ghana

China's international marketing in Ghana has adversely impacted environmental sustainability and customer experience. The Chinese involvement in developing hydropower has been done under weak contractual settings with poor regulatory frameworks (Hensengerth, 2013). Illegal Chinese-run organizations in Ghana have led to substantial environmental deterioration (Hilson et al., 2014). In Ghana, customer experience is adversely impacted by the deterioration of beaches, forest reserves, waterfalls, lakes, rivers, animals, and beautiful landscapes like mountains and valleys. Forest vegetation, animals, birds, insects, and important tree species, which are excellent attractions to most tourists, have witnessed massive deterioration, with 80% disappearing in the past 100 years (International Resource Panel, 2011).

4.3 | Research design

Our study applies a mixed method research design, which involves concurrent use of both quantitative and qualitative methods, with quantitative preceding the qualitative and exploratory method (sequential use in the reverse order). This research design provides additional rigor (Creswell & Clark, 2017). The sustainability performance quantitative data analysis preceded the qualitative data collection. The PLS method was used for the quantitative data analysis. In contrast, the Atlas Ti qualitative software was used to emerge themes from the quantitative study to explain the hows and whys of the quantitative results. We wish to note that striving for this cross-market customer experience elicited by a theoretical sampling plan is a central function of grounded theory procedures to develop generalized concepts. Although our qualitative research results provide only a starting point, we believe that marketing research could significantly contribute to a better understanding of how to realize organizational ambidexterity by drawing on this new perspective of interaction patterns between marketing capabilities. Sustainability by itself sells (Fraß & Walter, 2021), and generating customer touch points cross-culturally from a local perspective is a starting point.

4.4 | Data collection

The target population was organizations and customers defined as groups with common defining characteristics that the researcher can identify in a study (Creswell & Clark, 2017).

The quantitative data was gathered through a survey of tourism businesses from three regions of southern Ghana. These regions were chosen for this study because most tourism businesses and destinations are found there. The study area is more integral to the country's economic development in employment, revenue generation, and infrastructure development. The sector is also dependent on natural resources for its functioning, and the sustainability of the resources is essential to the continuous existence of the tourism sector. In all, 313 usable questionnaires were retrieved and were used to carry out the analysis, hence with a response rate of 78%. The qualitative data was collected from seven Ministry of Tourism officials and three local customers, comprising 10 participants. The participant sample size reflects sample sizes relevant to qualitative studies, typically ranging from five to 15 (Schouten, 1991). McCracken (1988) argues that for a qualitative study, the respondents should be perfect strangers and few and have exceptional knowledge of the topic under study. In qualitative data collection approaches, the sample size may not always be defined as a priori. Instead, data may be collected until conceptual saturation is attained.

4.5 | Data analysis

With the data analysis, the current study carefully chose the constructs that could have provided possible empirical support and are

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TABLE 1 Factor loadings, VIF, validity, and reliability of latent construct.

Items	Loadings	t-values	p-values	VIF	CA	Rho_A	CR	AVE
BIO11	0.677	17.417	0.000	1.219	0.816	0.836	0.864	0.516
BIO4	0.616	10.301	0.000	2.175				
BIO5	0.739	16.828	0.000	2.856				
BIO6	0.833	28.901	0.000	2.816				
BIO8	0.703	14.216	0.000	2.004				
BIO9	0.723	11.616	0.000	2.142				
CEP1	0.784	22.075	0.000	1.922	0.853	0.857	0.892	0.582
CEP2	0.608	7.938	0.000	1.508				
CEP3	0.841	36.402	0.000	2.382				
CEP4	0.817	24.551	0.000	2.653				
CEP5	0.742	15.962	0.000	1.885				
CEP6	0.762	21.227	0.000	1.802				
WEC3	0.781	19.867	0.000	1.779	0.795	0.826	0.857	0.548
WEC4	0.854	42.173	0.000	2.085				
WEC5	0.634	7.472	0.000	1.508				
WEC6	0.766	21.147	0.000	1.568				
WEC7	0.643	8.165	0.000	1.459				
WSM1	0.729	14.749	0.000	1.717	0.850	0.876	0.888	0.573
WSM2	0.851	36.09	0.000	2.512				
WSM3	0.782	27.898	0.000	1.701				
WSM5	0.663	10.038	0.000	1.518				
WSM6	0.642	11.436	0.000	1.402				
WSM7	0.847	35.287	0.000	2.451				

Note: VIF = Variance inflation factor; CA = Cronbach's Alpha; CR = Composite Reliability; AVE = Average Variance Extracted.

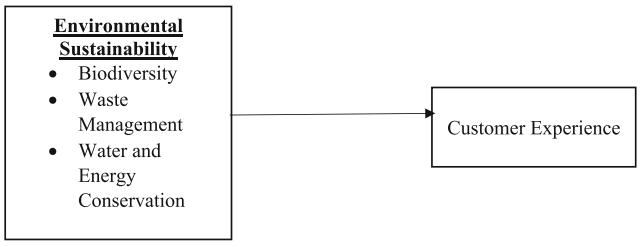
compatible with existing theories, conceptualizations, and managerial practice. Partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) was used for the quantitative data analysis. Partial least squares structural equation modeling (PLS-SEM) has gained popularity as a tool of analysis to estimate complex path models between and among latent variables (Hair et al., 2017; Sarstedt et al., 2017). The qualitative data analysis was conducted with officials of the Ghana Tourist Board in the three regions, and this was analyzed with open and axial coding using the Atlas Ti qualitative analysis software. Open and axial coding for data analysis: Open coding ensured that codes were derived directly from the data by creating categories, labeling, and organizing data to highlight different themes. Axial coding identified relationships between the concepts described by these codes.

5 | FINDINGS

The qualitative interviews revealed themes of poor waste management, noise pollution, and a lack of regulatory framework. The themes from the qualitative study support the quantitative study.

Mixed method research involves the integration of qualitative and quantitative method philosophies, designs, strategies, analytic approaches, and interpretations (Creswell & Tashakkori, 2007; Greene, 2006; Tashakkori & Teddlie, 2003) (Table 1).

5.1 | Framework



5.2 | Measurement model assessment

The model's reliability and validity are reported in Table 2. The findings reveal that all the measures have satisfactory internal

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consistency. Thus, both indices of Cronbach alpha (CA) values ranging from (0.795 to 0.853) and Composite Reliability (CR) values ranging from (0.857 to 0.892) exceeded the recommended thresholds of 0.7 (Bagozzi & Yi, 1988). Regarding convergent validity, all the outer loadings are between 0.608 and 0.854, and the indices of Average Variance Explain (AVE) values range from (0.516 to 0.582), exceeding the acceptable threshold of 0.50 (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). The evidence suggests the measures have an acceptable degree of convergent validity (Hair et al., 2017) (Figures 1–3).

5.3 | Discriminant validity

The discriminant validity of the scale was tested using cross-loading, Fornell and Larcker (1981) criterion, and Heterotrait–Monotrait (HTMT) approach (Henseler et al., 2015).

As depicted in Table 2, all figures on the diagonals are more significant than those below, indicating that discriminant validity is attained. According to Hair et al. (2012), discriminant validity using the Fornell-Larcker criterion at the construct level can be achieved if the square root of the AVE is greater than the highest correlation between the latent variable and the other constructs.

TABLE 2 Discriminant validity by Fornell Larcker criterion.

	BIO	CEP	WEC	WSM
BIO	0.718			
CEP	0.499	0.763		
WEC	0.448	0.626	0.741	
WSM	0.710	0.568	0.515	0.757

Results presented in Table 3 show that the outer loadings of each indicator were more significant on its respective latent variable than its cross-loadings on any other latent variables. This also confirms the attainment of discriminant validity.

Moreover, the HTMT values ranging from (0.495 to 0.838), are below the threshold value of 0.85 (Henseler et al., 2015) or 0.90 (Hair et al., 2012), as indicated in Table 4 provides evidence of discriminant validity (Henseler et al., 2015).

5.4 | Hypothesis testing

From the indices shown in Table 5, it indicates that the path coefficients and the *p-values* showed that out of the three (3) hypotheses

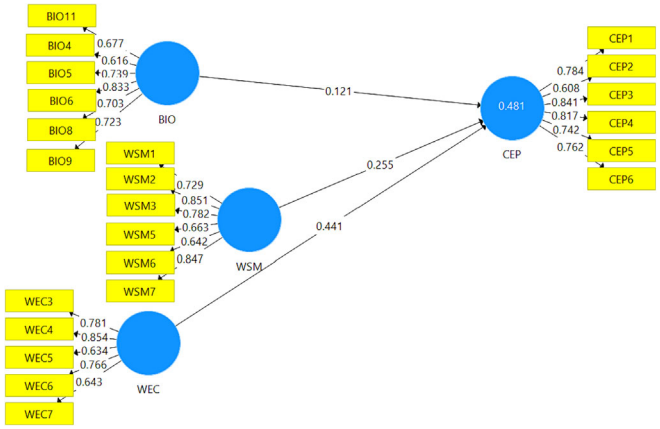


FIGURE 2 Measurement model. Source: estimate from SmartPLS.

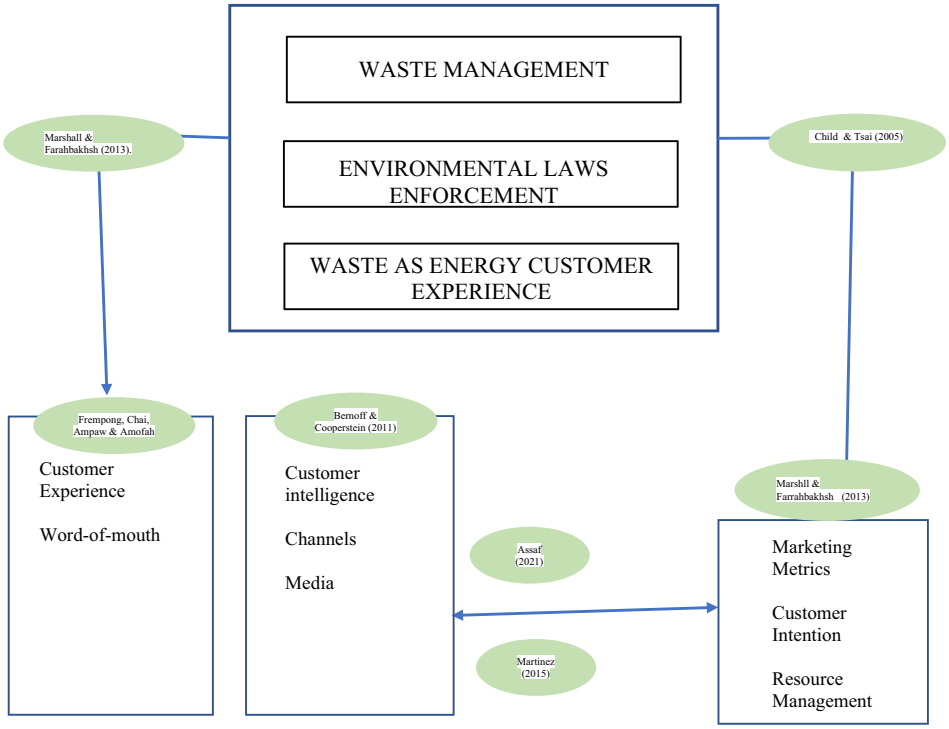


FIGURE 1 Customer experience management through environmental sustainability cross-market customer experience touchpoints. (Adapted from Verhoef, Reinartz & Krafft, 2010).

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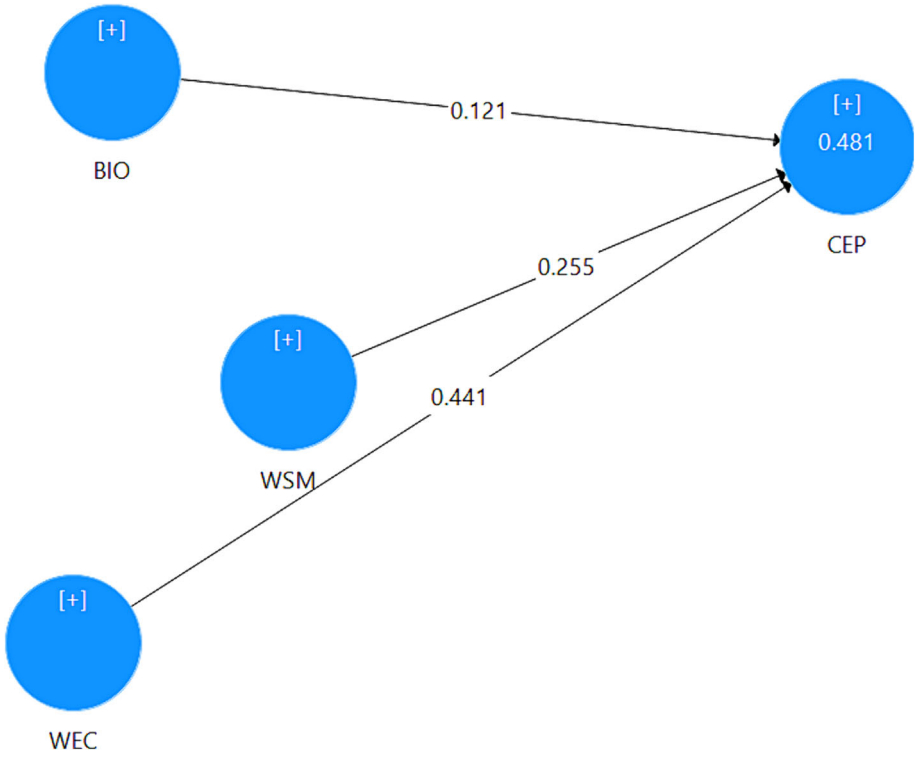


FIGURE 3 Structural model. Source: SmartPLS estimate.

TABLE 3 Discriminant validity by cross loading.

	BIO	CEP	WEC	WSM
BIO11	**0.677**	0.504	0.464	0.567
BIO4	**0.616**	0.227	0.115	0.460
BIO5	**0.739**	0.273	0.268	0.580
BIO6	**0.833**	0.347	0.339	0.507
BIO8	**0.703**	0.385	0.292	0.417
BIO9	**0.723**	0.246	0.298	0.502
CEP1	0.392	**0.784**	0.453	0.455
CEP2	0.394	**0.608**	0.368	0.499
CEP3	0.318	**0.841**	0.512	0.470
CEP4	0.383	**0.817**	0.489	0.347
CEP5	0.317	**0.742**	0.484	0.381
CEP6	0.469	**0.762**	0.539	0.440
WEC3	0.286	0.478	**0.781**	0.265
WEC4	0.372	0.576	**0.854**	0.433
WEC5	0.183	0.276	**0.634**	0.288
WEC6	0.422	0.530	**0.766**	0.492
WEC7	0.349	0.372	**0.643**	0.409
WSM1	0.725	0.360	0.385	**0.729**
WSM2	0.625	0.478	0.498	**0.851**
WSM3	0.543	0.533	0.464	**0.782**
WSM5	0.328	0.274	0.284	**0.663**

tested, one (1) path relationship (BIO→CEP) was insignificant (i.e., Hypothesis H1). Specifically, WEC significantly predicted CEP ($\beta = 0.440$; $t = 5.091$; $p = 0.000$), indicating a one-unit increase in WEC will increase the expected value of CEP by 0.440, thereby supporting Hypothesis H1. Also, WSM significantly predicted CEP ($\beta = 0.255$; $t = 2.717$; $p = 0.007$), indicating a one-unit increase in WSM will increase the expected value of CEP by 0.255, thereby supporting Hypothesis H3. Therefore, Hypothesis H1 is rejected, while Hypotheses H2 and H3 are supported, respectively.

TABLE 4 Discriminant validity by Heterotrait–Monotrait (HTMT).

	BIO	CEP	WEC	WSM
BIO				
CEP	0.548			
WEC	0.495	0.729		
WSM	0.838	0.645	0.600	

Table 6 above shows the dependent variable's predictive relevance (Q2) and predictive power (R2). From Table 6, it indicates that the structural model has an acceptable level of predictive relevance ($Q^2 > 0.258$) and predictive power ($R^2 > 0.481$) (Hair et al., 2017; Usakli & Kucukergin, 2018). Specifically, the R^2 value of 0.481 indicates that the model explains 48.1% of the variation in customer experience (CEP). Also, Q^2 of the model was 0.258, which is >0.0, establishing that the PLS structural model has predictive relevance.

5.5 | Qualitative interview

The Qualitative interview explains the importance of environmental sustainability to the customer experience by answering the how and

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TABLE 5 Path relationships.

Hypothesis	Path	VIF	β	SE	*t*-value	*p*-value	*Decision*
H1	BIO→CEP	0.121	0.126	0.083	1.451	0.147	Relegated
H2	WEC→CEP	0.441	0.440	0.087	5.091	0.000	Supported
H3	WSM→CEP	0.255	0.257	0.094	2.717	0.007	Supported

TABLE 6 Results showing predictive relevance and predictive power.

Latent	Q^2	R^2	AJ. R^2
CEP	0.258	0.481	0.474

whys by emerging the following themes of waste management, enforcement of regulatory framework, and waste as energy:

5.5.1 | Waste management

> Mining air pollution and littering of the beaches are some of the evil experiences. Inadequate rainfall causes you to lose the water bodies. Bush fires cause us to lose animals and vegetation, so customers cannot see the animals they want. Also, the heat waves occur, and the river bodies like the waterfalls are destroyed. The effect of 'galamsey' has brought about a lousy tourism experience. The Chinese, with much money, use chemicals to destroy nature and cut down trees. The customers therefore have a very bad experience. Customers may even want to drink and they may catch diseases on their bodies and they may get poisoned. The flow of the water is affected so the water is not available for swimming. The aquatic life is also affected. Most of the things we use to produce energy also affect the environment so energy conservation like solar panels.
>
> (Official 1, Ministry of Tourism)

The narration of Official 1 is in line with the perspectives of Maignan and Ferrell (2004), who call for a more universal and comprehensive corporate management strategy that can gather environmental intelligence and disseminate market information to broader stakeholders with the help of marketing systems responsive to customer needs. As good sanitation, environmental conditions, and social and economic sustainability performance are adhered to, waste management becomes under control. Official 2 narrates:

> Deforestation, indiscriminate tree-cutting, and illegal mining badly affect the environment. When the water is contaminated, the water dries up and customers cannot get the actual satisfaction they are looking for. The customer gets disease from the water bodies and pollution of the water itself destroys fishes and other living beings in the water so the customer cannot see these in the water and have a dissatisfying experience.
>
> (Official 2, Ministry of Tourism)

Official 2 indicates in his narration that environmental sustainability has not been encouraged through collaboration with Chinese foreigners whose indiscriminate activities together with the locals have led to the destruction of water bodies and vegetation in the country, which results in customer diseases. The narration of Official 2 highlights the increasing importance of customer value management, which has its roots in applying information to acquire and retain customers and driving customer behavior with developed marketing strategies (Beckers et al., 2014). Such strategies would involve putting oneself in the customer's shoes to prevent diseases caused by indiscriminate activities that adversely impact the environment.

An opportunity presents itself in these adverse circumstances for waste management. Official 3 indicates this fact in his narration:

> Waste management has the main effect on the environment. Mining is another problem. The harmonization of the human being on earth thrives on environmental resources. The cause of environmental problems is more than the natural environment, including the artificial environment. There is so much waste caused by customers on site. The animal species is not well sustained and the pollution and lumbering without replanting is very hostile to the environment. The whole forest is not understood. The alternative livelihood of the locals is also affected. Greening is affected and the lifestyle of the ecosystem is limited and affects most of the tourist sites. The holistic responsibility and families who depend on the environment are affected. So those who exploit the natural resources need the appropriate environment. All of this presents an opportunity for waste management.
>
> (Official 3, Ministry of Tourism)

As indicated by Official 3, waste management is an opportunity for the customer to engage in environmental sustainability. As discussed by Beckers et al. (2018), customer experience behaviors are essential in today's connected world. Such behaviors provide a platform for excellent customer experience. Therefore, companies launching initiatives to stimulate customer experience could benefit from waste management. Customer experience in the feedback for environmental sustainability can leverage social media for waste management as a strategic approach to environmental sustainability. According to Frempong et al. (2020), waste management has engaged

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the attention of governments, policymakers, and academics for the health and well-being of consumers. Our study validates this fact and discovers that consumers can engage in sustainable collaboration for waste management by providing feedback to emerging market tourist officials. This feedback also assists the governments in their environmental regulation. The existence of a well-developed and dependable regulatory framework is therefore essential, as indicated by Official 4 in his narration below:

5.5.2 | Enforcement of regulatory framework

Emerging markets operate under institutional voids and a limited regulatory framework (Doh et al. (2017). A Ghanaian customer who has experienced the effects of environmental degradation offers his views:

> Unfortunately, we do not have a regulatory framework for environmental sustainability. There is no standard practice because we find the collaborators lenient, so there is no protocol, so we need a regulatory framework. So, to work at these frameworks, we need people with the knowledge and skillset to do this. So, either we set up an institution to regulate environment sustainability and customer experience. If foreign companies come here (to Ghana), it is not incumbent on them to come up with the best practices unless we enforce them but we are not knowledgeable in those matters so we need to set an institution for this. We should establish an institution for this.
>
> (Ghanaian environmental customer 1)

The Ghanaian customer advocates for the establishment of an institution to ensure environmental sustainability and great customer experience. This view aligns with the perspectives and discoveries of Bhattacharya and Sen (2003), who indicate that conditions exist under which customers enter strong, committed, and meaningful relationships with certain companies and become champions of them and their products. This customer–company identification, including the company identity, can be spearheaded by establishing such an institution. Child and Tsai (2005) provide institutional and political perspectives to develop a framework for strategies for environmental protection in emerging economies. In contrast to local firms in the same sector, the study offers new insights into a political perspective that leads to proactivity. In line with these perspectives, our study finds that cross-market consumer experience begins with positive collaboration at the macro or governmental level to establish and enforce environmental regulations.

Official 5 agrees that the Ministry of Tourism and its customers have a role in all this environmental sustainability. He details:

> The destruction of forests affects the trees and the animals in there is one aspect of environmental destruction. Cutting of trees, illegal mining, destroys the beauty of the environment. Illegal mining destroys the tourism sites – the river bodies, waterfalls etc. are destroyed. There is also poor waste management as a result – sewage pollution and poor waste management. We have a book for customers to provide their feedback at the tourist sites.
>
> (Official 5, Ministry of Tourism)

A customer-oriented system to encourage more environmentally and ecologically conscious businesses would prevent cutting trees but encourage tree planting; conserving animal species and plants would go a long way to improve climatic conditions (Arshad et al., 2021). Official 5, therefore, encourages the idea that the Ministry of Tourism can encourage an excellent customer-oriented system for environmental sustainability. Child and Tsai (2005) provide institutional and political perspectives to develop a framework for strategies for environmental protection in emerging economies. In contrast to local firms in the same sector, the study offers new insights into a political perspective that leads to proactivity. In line with these perspectives, our study finds that cross-market consumer experience begins with positive collaboration at the macro or governmental level to establish and enforce environmental regulations.

Good local community practices are also responsible for environmental sustainability, as indicated by Official 6 from the Ministry of Tourism:

> The livelihood of the local community and culture are also severely affected when the foreigners affect the environment. If the environment is destroyed, the government blocks out the area. Where there is mining, there is money, you do not need to build schools, and the local community does not need to depend on the government. The rivers are polluted and those left are gathering diseases. There is also depletion of the forest and the government does not seem to have the control of capacity to regulate the environment. Social vices also increase as a result. We are all not adhering to standards but they (foreigners) come here and undermine the importance of the natural resources because they need their results. So, they come with their money and do not reclaim the land so the country and the local and even foreign customers suffer. All the standards speak of environmental health so the foreign customer should be also engaged in the enforcement of these laws. That is why their feedback is so important.
>
> (Official 6, Ministry of Tourism)

Official 6 indicates that the vulnerable local communities also suffer from a lack of environmental sustainability because the foreign companies are eager to recoup their profits. Bernoff et al. (2011) indicate that consumers can enhance the communities in which they operate by supporting firms in developing these communities and

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applying their manufacturing strength, distribution power, and information mastery, which are competitive strengths and advantages for the firm. In emerging markets, this is particularly useful for firms and consumer experience. Our study discovers that although emerging market customers may not be privy to these social networks, they have the power of social networks and use this to assist in achieving environmental sustainability. This is a call to emerging market firms to leverage this customer experience.

5.5.3 | Waste as energy customer experience

Marshall and Farahbakhsh (2013) recommend an adaptive thinking system that consumers can apply for solid waste management in emerging markets to compensate for the institutional voids. Marshall and Farahbakhsh (2013) indicate that environmental issues' health and environmental implications are mounting in urgency, particularly in the context of emerging markets. This perspective contrasts the focus in industrialized countries with a focus on the utilization of waste as energy. In industrialized countries, climate change, public health, resource scarcity, and public awareness and participation have been drivers in environmental sustainability. However, urbanization, inequality, economic growth, policy, governance, institutional issues, and related environmental and socio-cultural hostilities have exacerbated environmental sustainability issues in emerging markets (Marshall & Farahbakhsh, 2013). The conversion of waste into energy is a way for consumers to support environmental sustainability while assisting product development as a mode of experience.

Official 7 from the Ministry of Tourism in Ghana discusses how Ghanaian authorities have limited enforcement of laws to ensure environmental sustainability by limiting pollution. He narrates:

> Water contaminated reduces hygiene for the customer. Air pollution creates liver problems and created diseases — lung diseases and eye. Customers go to tourist sites for entertainment and some for peaceful rest. The food the person eats is also affected, and customers have illnesses at the end of the day. The authorities do not properly ensure the laws. There may be rules but enforcing them are problems. Plastic is being recycled to produce bags, chairs and other materials. Solid waste can be used to produce bio-gas and liquid and solid waste with urine and faeces as sewage is used for biogas for cooking and also electric power and waste left is used as manure for agriculture and other crops. Individual and institutional customers use this recycling for their energy which improves their experience at the destination. These customers are involved in the separation of the waste. Customers are educated and support environmental sustainability.
>
> (Official 7, Ministry of Tourism)

The proper enforcement of laws should protect customers who experience this pollution to their detriment to limit the destruction of the environment and noise pollution in the environment. Customer experience is, however, a resource in this situation as they share their ideas, knowledge, and networks. This support to create energy from waste materials by customers should, however, be initiated by local institutions as indicated by a local customer:

> The operation of foreigners to use our natural resources also leads to noise pollution that badly affects the customer. The customers, therefore, cannot enjoy the environment. There is an agency that regulates tourism but with eagerness to get more business from foreigners, the staff get negligent and cannot ensure that all the laws are obeyed. So, we need the customer to be part of this enforcement.
>
> (Ghanaian customer 2)

When customers comply with the laws by adhering to environmental sustainability, they benefit from a healthier life as tourists. Customers can also go further in assisting to conserve energy. The cross-market customer can imitate such innovation to prevent bad experiences through their feedback.

> There is food contamination as germs fall on the food. Customers who visit suffer from increased diseases from pollution, poor sewage management, and unhealthy foods. This destruction of the environment is also a dent on the country's reputation. Instead of reaping from the arable land, they are now destroying it, so scenic areas are becoming dangerous. The national grid water system is affected because the water is destroyed and the system to harvest the natural water is limited. There is limited energy conservation because of the deforestation so there is so much heat. The modern systems to conserve energy are being used and we need more of these from the Chinese foreigners who should focus on these. Marketing officers would take note of this.
>
> (Official 7, Ministry of Tourism).

Official 7 indicates that consumers should be interested in conserving energy. In line with the perspectives of Boyd et al. (2010), Official 7 from the Ministry of Tourism suggests that Chief Marketing Officers have an important role in harnessing customer power. Our study shows that such customer power can be directed towards excellent customer experience through environmental sustainability. Chuah et al. (2020) refer to customer power stemming from environmental concern and green trust. Some local officials agree that customers do complain, but a cross-national effort is needed in response to these complaints; a Ghanaian customer specifies in his statement:

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> Tourism becomes very expensive because customers complain about all this pollution. The noises scare the animals away. The noises also adversely affect the tourist. In areas of low investment, the outdoor activities are not underground as they should be. The tourist attractions do not become tourist attractions since the vegetation is so much destroyed. To solve this problem should be a cross-national effort.
>
> (Ghanaian customer 3)

The present work justifies the understanding of the impact of pollution of the environment on customer experience in emerging markets. Ghanaian customer 3 complains about tourist attractions that are destroyed. These aspects of risks limit customer experience in emerging markets since they are harmful. This motivates us to investigate the role of customer experience in sustainable collaborations between emerging markets. Therefore, we examine extant research on customer experience in a cross-cultural context to illuminate the collaboration of firms from different emerging markets to enhance customer experience.

We argue that commercial exchanges involving two emerging markets could produce material and experiential purchases that enhance customer experience. Schmitt et al. (2015) determine that the experiential purchases of customers are not two ends of a spectrum but do not form one continuum. Cross-cultural customer experience from purchasing from emerging markets based on emerging market firm collaborations could be dynamic and not necessarily on a continuum. Zhang et al. (2008) call for a new perspective from cross-cultural research that delves into these topics further.

6 | DISCUSSION

This research utilizes both qualitative and quantitative research to explore the impact of environmental sustainability issues on customers in emerging economies. In this instance, it is about Ghana. However, based on the interviewees' reactions, it could be posited that it could apply to any emerging economy rich in natural resources that foreign companies are exploiting. In this case, where China is supporting the companies and infrastructure development, they may be hampering future economic development opportunities by creating a negative perception for Chinese companies, and this would hold for other countries engaging in similar behavior. Given that those emerging economies become customer economies over time, these negative sentiments will impact the entry of customer brands from these countries in the future. It would behoove countries to take a long-term perspective and recognize that the short-term gains of disregarding sustainable projects will have long-term negative economic impacts.

As emerging economies develop and customers observe the first-hand impacts of foreign resource exploitation, they become more sensitive to green issues, especially environmental sustainability. Customer experience is targeted towards green marketing, which is the presentation of sustainable practices versus sustainable business practices, which are the experience in sustainable practices throughout the production and distribution process. Customers in foreign markets observe the damage wrought by bad practices and take responsibility for environmental sustainability that supports the green marketing of firms.

This study introduces three strategic directions for designing CEs in emerging markets: waste management, enforcement of environmental regulations, and reduction of environmental pollution. We propose that these three directions as customer touchpoints promoted by Marketing Managers of firms (see propositions) could advance environmental sustainability between and within emerging markets. The result could be an environmentally desirable experience for consumers globally. We propose that the strategic directions extend to cross-markets by consideration of a cross-market approach. As such, we extend customer engagement (CE) management by adding these essential strategic directions, renewing CE touchpoint journey design when environmental sustainability is considered. Recent research highlights the emerging relevance of CE. However, our study shows reinforcement in emerging markets by considering the strategic directions as customer touchpoints - focusing on real-time insights into how consumers can engage in environmental sustainability globally.

6.1 | Managerial implications

We introduced Cross-market CEM as a higher-order resource that entails a cross-market approach toward customer experiences, strategic directions for designing customer experiences, and firm capabilities to continuously renew customer experiences, aiming to achieve and sustain long-term global customer loyalty. This cross-market approach provides a stronger foundation for environmental sustainability. Therefore, practitioners involved in CEM must be aware that this cross-market customer experience focus is more effective for environmental sustainability. It embodies consideration of the foreign customer in the corporate culture and a global customer experience mindset, which can facilitate the coordination efforts of customer experience design. Executives, in turn, might use their oversight to guide the establishment of a dynamic capability system and to foster the firm's overall dedication to long-term customer loyalty.

6.2 | Limitations and future research directions

The primary limitation is that the study uses one target country and one source of emerging market entities, so it cannot be generalizable. However, given the rapid expansion of China with their initiatives in Africa (and other emerging markets), similar findings and responses on the dynamics of the relationship with the environment in Africa and other resource-rich emerging markets may be alluded to in the responses.

It is clear from the results that foreign actors do not take their environmental impact seriously and subsequently generate a lot of negative emotions in the local market. This will have a halo effect on

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other companies with the same country of origin as the exploited. This area would be ripe for further study, i.e., exploring the country-of-origin effect on brands when a country's initial exposure to a foreign country is one where resource extraction has taken place and, in the case of Ghana, has been abused. Our study finds that customer experience for environmental sustainability through social media is an opportunity in emerging markets because of the extensive social networks and rich endowment of natural resources.

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